Data availability

Chemical
pH (1:5)
Macronutrients (N,Ca, P...)
Micronutrients (Fe,Mb,Cu...)

Biological
Organic Matter (%)
C/N Ratio
Organic carbon (%)

Physical
Clay (%)
Silt (%)
Sand (%)
Texture



Risks

The case operates within a dense policy environment. In Germany, GAEC minimum soil cover (enhanced CAP conditionality) and the Fertiliser Ordinance/Law (DÜV/DüngG) define the compliance baseline. Any credited outcome must exceed these standards to satisfy CRCF additionality and durability requirements. As this is also a risk for the buyers of certificates and partner institutions, CO_2-Land maintains a 20% buffer of the expected carbon storage potential across all project areas. This reserve serves to compensate for lower-than-expected soil carbon gains on certain plots or farms

Preliminary results

SOC accumulation depends strongly on environmental factors such as climate, region, and soil type, which means that humus losses due to weather or site conditions may occur. Consequently, the success of humus-building measures cannot be guaranteed. CO2 considers this risk for participating farmers by guaranteeing that participating farmers do not face any penalties if soil organic matter levels stagnate or even decrease over time. In such cases, the only cost is incurred by soil tests. Also, to mitigate this risk, if stagnating SOC levels are detected with soil tests, potential causes are analysed

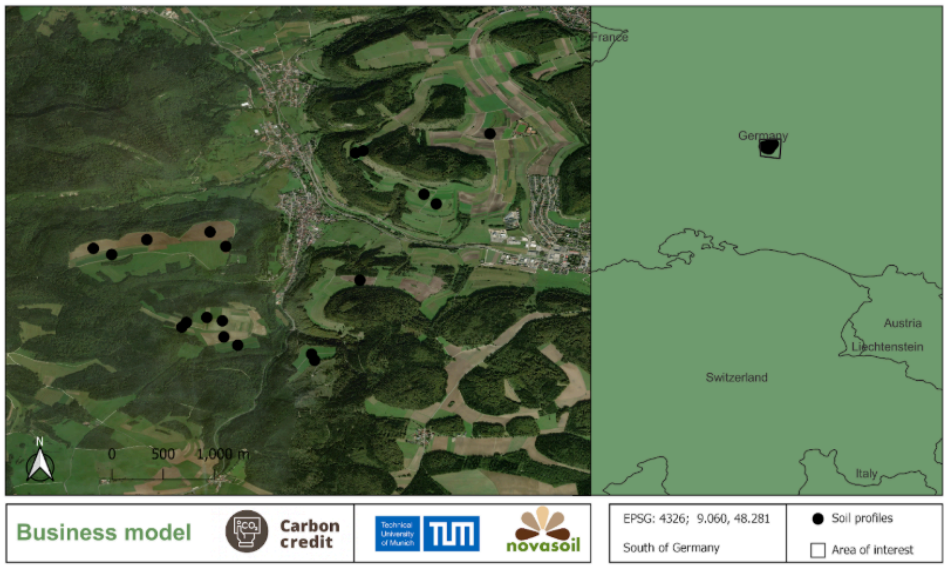
Economic perspective

The park's financing combines a basic operational layer with a results-based layer. The first ensures steady funding from the regular parks budget for routine maintenance and soil-friendly practices, providing cash flow stability. The second rewards measurable ecosystem outcomes, using transparent tariffs per unit delivered. Ecosystem-service valuation tools (e.g., i-Tree, InVEST) translate these outcomes into monetary terms, strengthening accountability and co-funding opportunities. Funding responsibility is shared: the base is covered by the parks budget, while results payments come from the departments that benefit directly, supplemented by CSR or climate funds. Multi-year agreements give financial certainty, and framework contracts plus digital monitoring reduce costs and administrative burden.

Policy and governance

The case operates within a dense policy environment. In Germany, GAEC minimum soil cover (enhanced CAP conditionality) and the Fertiliser Ordinance/Law (DÜV/DüngG) define the compliance baseline. Any credited outcome must exceed these standards to satisfy CRCF additionality and durability requirements. To monitor the development of SOC levels, soils are tested at the beginning of the contract and in the fourth and tenth year after the contract starts. In their efforts to increase SOC, participating farmers are supported with agronomic advice provided by CO2-Land advisors.

CO2-Land initiative in Germany



NOVASOIL

The NOVASOIL project aims to demonstrate the benefits of investing in soil health for society and the environment.
The main outcome of the project is an instrument for assessing the suitability of different business models to promote soil health.
This tool is based on best-practice examples in Europe and other countries and is tailored to the needs and requirements of the stakeholders.

“Bodenfruchtbarkeitsfonds”



Summary

Soil fertility is declining due to overuse and unsustainable management of agricultural land, which increases pressure on farms and leads to soil degradation. The EU estimates humus losses at €38 billion annually.

The Soil Fertility Fund (BFF) provides financial and technical support to farmers in maintaining and improving soil fertility. With donations, the costs of fertility-enhancing measures can be compensated. This initiative aims to raise awareness of soil fertility and create broad social support for its preservation and development. In the long term, the fund contributes to strengthening soil fertility on agricultural land and to achieving climate and environmental goals. The case study illustrates the success factors and the potential for more efficient environmental programmes.

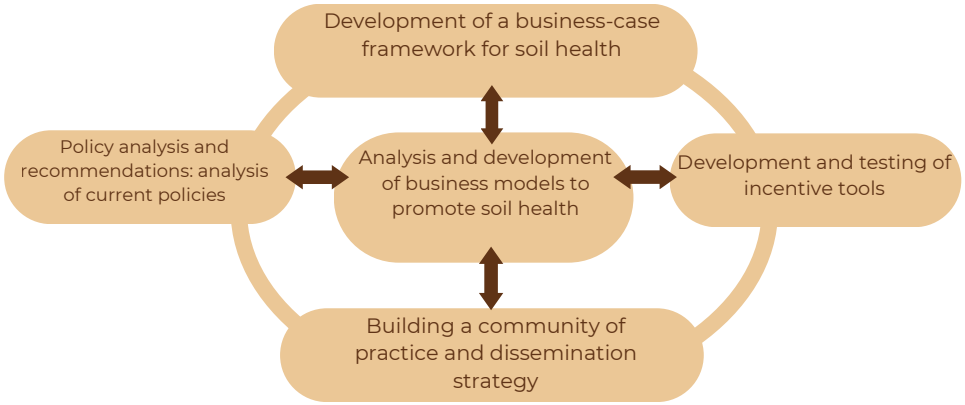


Figure 1. NOVASOIL project structure

Characteristics of the case studies

Potential inhibitors

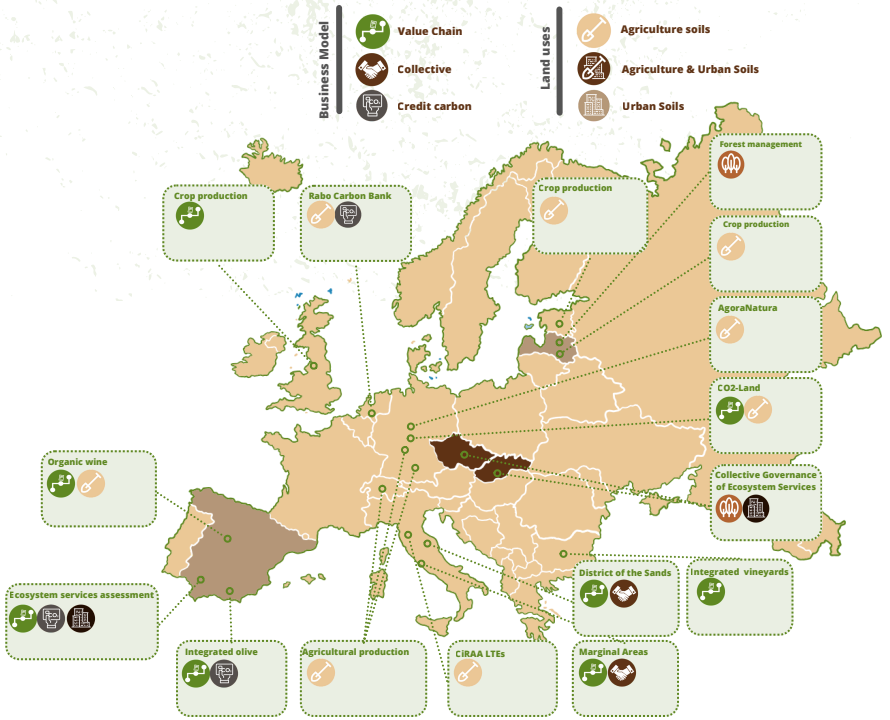
Lack of interest/acceptance among farmers (e.g. due to restrictions in the cultivation of certain crops/incompatibility with current farming systems). Financial/return model.

Potential enabler

Societal awareness (consumers who demand high-quality and healthy food respond to environmentally friendly production), farmers who react with sustainable practices.
Existing networks and associations.
Political framework.

Potential stakeholders

The BFF allows consumers to become sponsors of soil fertility for the land that provides their food. A donation of €100 or 112 CHF per year supports the fertility of 2,500 m² of land. Farmers and companies can also contribute to the concept through donations.





Specific objectives

SO1 Development of a multidimensional portfolio of business cases and good practices for investments in soil health in Europe and beyond.

SO2 Analysis of current models worldwide to create new incentives and new revenues from healthy soils.

SO3 Application of a co-development concept in modelling to promote soil health.

SO4 Development of a prototype for an incentive toolbox and a test network.

SO5 Analysis of current policies and technologies related to soil health and farmers' income security.

SO6 Building a community of practice among investors and key soil health actors.

SO7 Increasing interest in soil health through a digital marketing strategy plan.

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novasoil

INNOVATIVE BUSINESS MODELS FOR SOIL HEALTH

https://novasoil-project.eu

